

# LOCUS Intelligence Dossier: McMenamins Anderson School, Bothell WA

**Address:** 18607 Bothell Way NE, Bothell, WA 98011 **Prepared:** April 2, 2026 **Primary use case:** Market analysis / competitive intelligence **Persona:** Middle-aged single male technology entrepreneur **Priority dimensions:** Business environment & foot traffic; Food/drink & social scene

## THE LOCUS SCORECARD

| # | Dimension                   | Score | Tier      | One-Line Verdict                                                                                                                                                                      |
|---|-----------------------------|-------|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Walkability & Daily Errands | 7/10  | Strong    | QFC grocery at 2 minutes and a Walk Score near 80 deliver real car-optional daily life, but the walkable radius thins fast past Main Street.                                          |
| 2 | Food, Drink & Social Scene  | 7/10  | Strong    | Seattle Met's 2025 Culinary Suburb of the Year — Krō Bär and Amaro Bistro anchor a legitimate emerging scene, but the fine-dining ceiling and late-night energy still trail Kirkland. |
| 3 | Recreation & Green Space    | 8/10  | Excellent | A 30-mile paved trail network starts 7 minutes on foot, a heated saltwater pool sits on-site, and an 89-acre riverfront open space is in active planning.                             |
| 4 | Education & Family          | 8/10  | Excellent | Northshore SD ranks top 5% statewide and UW Bothell's 6,361-student campus is a 15-minute walk — more relevant here as a talent pipeline than a family asset.                         |
| 5 | Transportation & Commute    | 5/10  | Moderate  | Bellevue in 18 minutes off-peak is fine; Bellevue at 50 minutes during rush hour is not. Stride BRT (Q2 2028) will add a step-change, but today the I-405/SR-522 bottleneck is real.  |
| 6 | Community & Civic Character | 7/10  | Strong    | A pedestrianized Main Street, an 80%+ independent business ratio, and a Pop Shops micro-business incubator signal an authentically entrepreneurial community, not a corporate suburb. |
| 7 | Neighborhood Trajectory     | 9/10  | Excellent | IonQ's \$1B quantum computing investment, 1,000+ housing units in pre-application, eliminated parking                                                                                 |

| # | Dimension                               | Score         | Tier          | One-Line Verdict                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|---|-----------------------------------------|---------------|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|   |                                         |               |               | mandates, and Stride BRT groundbreaking — this is the Eastside's most aggressive growth arc below Bellevue.                                                                                                         |
| 8 | <b>Business Viability</b> (1.5× weight) | 7/10          | <b>Strong</b> | A 60-company biotech cluster, UW Bothell's STEM pipeline, \$36/SF retail rents (half of Bellevue), and rising foot traffic from 1,300+ new downtown residents create a viable but still-maturing commercial market. |
| 9 | <b>LOCUS Composite Score</b>            | <b>7.2/10</b> | <b>Strong</b> | Bothell is a high-trajectory, mid-transformation market with genuine commercial upside — strong enough to build on today, with structural catalysts arriving through 2029.                                          |

*Composite methodology: Dimensions 2 and 8 weighted 1.5×; all others weighted 1×. Weighted average across 8 dimensions.*

## EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

**Strongest assets.** McMenamins Anderson School sits at the gravitational center of Bothell's downtown revival — a **5-acre hospitality campus** with seven food-and-beverage venues, a brewery, a 121-seat cinema, and a heated saltwater pool, all surrounded by a walkable corridor that Seattle Met named its **2025 Culinary Suburb of the Year**. (Marypong) Within a 10-minute walk, a tech entrepreneur can access a James Beard–pedigreed Italian restaurant (Amaro Bistro, 3 minutes), a 500-spirit craft cocktail bar run by a fellow tech founder (Krō Bär, 10 minutes), and a full-service QFC grocery (2 minutes). (Chamber of Commerce) The address is 15 minutes on foot from UW Bothell's record-enrollment campus of **6,361 students**, placing it directly adjacent to the region's most accessible university-based talent pipeline. Within a 5-mile drive, Canyon Park's biotech corridor employs **10,000+ workers** (Bothell WA) across companies including AGC Biologics (global HQ), IonQ (first U.S. quantum computing fab, **\$1B planned investment**), and Panasonic Avionics. Commercial rents averaging **\$36/SF retail** (LoopNet) (CommercialCafe) run roughly half of comparable Bellevue space, and the city has aggressively eliminated parking mandates while legalizing neighborhood-scale commercial across all residential zones.

**Most significant gaps.** The commute story is Bothell's clearest vulnerability. Peak-hour congestion on I-405 southbound can stretch a 15-minute off-peak drive to Bellevue into a **50-minute grind**, and SEA-TAC Airport sits 28 miles away (Rome2Rio) with no reliable sub-60-minute peak-hour path. Stride S3 BRT (Q2 2028 opening) (The Urbanist) (Mass Transit) and the I-405 dual express toll lane expansion will improve this, but the next two years will see active interchange demolition and weekend road closures that make the pain worse before it gets better. The social scene, while genuinely emerging, still lacks late-night energy — most venues close by 10 PM on

weeknights — and the fine-dining ceiling stops well below what Kirkland or Bellevue can offer for a high-stakes investor dinner. There is no rooftop bar, no waterfront dining, and no dedicated co-working space within walking distance (the nearest Regus is in Canyon Park). The downtown commercial market is healthy but thin: a single prolonged vacancy on Bothell Way would be visible in a way it wouldn't on a larger corridor.

**Overall verdict.** For a middle-aged single male tech entrepreneur conducting market analysis, this address presents a **high-upside, mid-risk commercial environment** at an inflection point. Bothell is past the speculative phase — \$150 million in public infrastructure is built, 1,300+ apartment units are occupied downtown, and institutional capital (IonQ, Trammell Crow, AvalonBay) has arrived. But it has not yet "arrived" in the way Kirkland's waterfront or Bellevue's Bel-Red corridor have. The gap between current reality and trajectory is the opportunity. An entrepreneur who establishes presence here in 2026 will benefit from lower operating costs, a loyal local customer base that is growing fast, and structural tailwinds (BRT, zoning reform, university expansion) that are already funded and in motion. The risk is timing: if you need the scene to be fully formed today, you're 3-4 years early.

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## SECTION 1 — POI HIGHLIGHTS: Top 5 that define daily life and commercial context

**1. McMenamins Anderson School campus (on-site, 0 min)** This is not merely a hotel — it functions as a **self-contained third-place ecosystem**. Seven distinct F&B venues ([Upstream Music Festival](#)) (Tavern on the Square, Nui Nui tiki bar, The Shed whiskey lounge, The Woodshop pub, Principal's Office, Theater Bar, plus the brewery), a 121-seat first-run cinema, ([mcmenamins](#)) a 112-foot heated saltwater pool, five private event spaces accommodating 10 to 600 guests, ([mcmenamins](#)) free community meeting room (Thorndike Room, seats 35), ([mcmenamins](#)) live music at Haynes' Hall, complimentary WiFi throughout, ([mcmenamins](#)) and a full espresso bar at The Market. For a tech entrepreneur, this single property replaces a co-working space, a client entertainment venue, a team-event location, a fitness facility, and a neighborhood social hub. **No comparable asset exists within any competing Eastside corridor.**

**2. Krō Bär (10116 Main St, 10-min walk)** A speakeasy-style craft cocktail bar ([Krobarbothell](#)) in a restored 1900s building with 16-foot tin ceilings, ~**500 spirits**, ([Seattlecocktailweek](#)) and a bartender ranked in the World Class US Top 100 (2024). ([Krobarbothell](#)) Owner Scott is himself a tech entrepreneur who built the bar after global tech-industry travel. ([Krobarbothell](#)) Rated **4.9/5 on OpenTable**. Max party of 4, 21+ only, ([OpenTable](#)) reservations essential. This is where a tech founder takes a potential co-founder, angel investor, or key hire for a conversation that matters. It participates in Seattle Cocktail Week 2026. For commercial intelligence purposes: Krō Bär's existence signals that downtown Bothell's consumer sophistication has crossed a critical threshold.

**3. UW Bothell / Cascadia College (18345 Campus Way NE, 15-min walk)** Record enrollment of **6,361 students** (autumn 2025, up 4.7% YoY), (King 5) AACSB-accredited School of Business (University of Washington B...) with entrepreneurship concentration, Computer Science and STEM programs, a makerspace in Discovery Hall, and connection to UW CoMotion's incubator network (300+ spinout companies, \$9.9B+ raised since 1984). (University of Washington) Cascadia College adds a BS in Computer Science and markets "**1,200+ tech businesses within a 10-mile radius.**" The campus generates **\$394 million in annual economic impact** and two-thirds of its 34,000+ alumni live within 25 miles. (University of Washington B...) For a tech entrepreneur, this is a walkable talent pipeline, guest-lecture platform, and innovation ecosystem anchor.

**4. Park at Bothell Landing & Sammamish River Trail (0.3 mi, 5-min walk)** A 6-acre riverfront park with amphitheater (600 capacity), kayak launch, playground, and a pedestrian bridge connecting directly to the **Sammamish River Trail / Burke-Gilman Trail** — a continuous 30-mile paved corridor (McMenamins) running from Marymoor Park in Redmond (King County) to Golden Gardens in Seattle. This trail is the spine of Eastside recreational life: morning runs, bike commutes, and weekend rides to Woodinville wine country (Economicalliancesc) (15 minutes by bike). The park hosts Summer Nights in Bothell (weekly Friday concerts, July–August), Movies in the Park, and the Holiday Light Display. For commercial context: these events generate **300–600 visitors per event** directly into the downtown dining corridor.

**5. QFC Grocery & Pharmacy (18921 Bothell Way NE, 2-min walk)** The unglamorous anchor that makes car-optional daily life possible. Full-service supermarket with in-store pharmacy, open 5 AM–1 AM daily, (Chamber of Commerce) located approximately 300 feet north of McMenamins on the same road. Eliminates the daily errand that forces most suburban dwellers into their cars. Combined with a bank at The Junction (6-min walk) and The Fitness Compound gym (8-min walk, 24/7 access), the 10-minute walk radius covers genuine daily essentials.

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## SECTION 2 — FOOD, DRINK & SOCIAL SCENE DEEP DIVE

### The working inventory within a 15-minute walk

**Cafés and coffee (work-from-café viability).** Caffè Ladro sits literally across the street — a Seattle-based specialty roaster rated 4.4/5 with 595 reviews, free WiFi, indoor/outdoor seating, and a relaxed laptop-friendly atmosphere. This is the daily driver. Social Grounds Coffee & Tea (3-min walk, rated 4.7/5, 415 reviews) offers an indie alternative. Daily Grind (10-min walk, zero-waste ethos) and T55 Pâtisserie (10-min walk, Southeast Asian–French fusion pastries including yuzu caramel lattes and Vietnamese egg coffee — featured in The Infatuation and Seattle Met) provide variety. A standard Starbucks at 19122 Beardslee Blvd (7-min walk) offers reliable backup. McMenamins' own Principal's Office (Washington Beer Blog) opens at 7 AM with house-roasted coffee. The work-from-café infrastructure is **adequate but not dense** — Caffè Ladro will be your default, and it's a good one.

**Restaurants (client entertainment quality).** Amaro Bistro is the clear top pick for a client dinner: **4.8/5 on OpenTable** (1,554 reviews), handmade pasta, extensive wine list, craft cocktails, sister restaurant to Il Bistro at Pike Place Market, 3-minute walk. The atmosphere is polished enough for a VC dinner but relaxed enough to feel authentic — the kind of Italian restaurant that converts skeptics about suburban dining. The Cottage (10-min walk) offers modern American scratch cooking ([The Cottage](#)) with live music nights, suitable for a more casual client dinner. Beardslee Public House (15-min walk, a John Howie Restaurant) pairs a 10-barrel on-site brewery with serious pub fare and houses **Wildwood Spirits Co.**, a distillery producing award-winning Kur gin and The Dark Door bourbon. ([Yelp](#)) For casual "let's talk shop over a beer" meetings, Beardslee is ideal. Beyond walking distance, the ILMU pop-up at T55 Pâtisserie offers a **\$125 tasting menu** from a Singapore-trained, Michelin-background chef ([Marypong](#)) — described by Seattle Met's food writer as "the best meal I ate last year." ([Seattle Met](#)) Poquitos (at The Junction, adjacent to McMenamins) brings Capitol Hill-pedigree Mexican. Prime Steakhouse also sits at The Junction. ([The Registry](#))

**Bars and cocktail venues (networking scene).** **Krō Bär is the anchor** — a genuine destination cocktail bar that would hold its own in any Seattle neighborhood. Beyond Krō Bär, McMenamins alone offers five distinct bars: The Shed (whiskey and fireplace, indoor/outdoor), Nui Nui (tiki bar, 80+ rums, poolside), ([OpenTable](#)) The Woodshop (pinball, shuffleboard, casual), Principal's Office (intimate top-floor hotel bar), and the Theater Bar. The Hop and Hound ([Begin at Bothell](#)) on Main Street ([Begin at Bothell](#)) adds a craft beer taproom with a dog-friendly beer garden and Food Truck Fridays. Side Hustle Local runs 24 taps including its own Original Gangster Brewery ([Side Hustle](#)) beers. The Bine Beer & Food is a beer-forward gastropub and known Burke-Gilman Trail stop. **The viable evening circuit:** drinks at Krō Bär → dinner at Amaro Bistro → nightcap at The Shed by the fireplace. That is a solid evening.

**Breweries and taprooms.** Two genuine breweries within walking distance (McMenamins Anderson School Brewery, 10-barrel system; ([Begin at Bothell](#)) Beardslee Public House, 10-barrel system + Wildwood Spirits distillery). ([Yelp](#)) ([Bothellkenmorechamber](#)) Multiple taprooms (Hop and Hound, Side Hustle Local, The Bine). Within a short drive: 192 Brewing and Postdoc Brewing in Kenmore. Woodinville wine country (160+ wineries, 10-minute drive) extends the beverages portfolio dramatically. ([Chapman Homes](#)) ([Economicalliancesc](#))

## Scene density assessment

Downtown Bothell's walkable corridor from McMenamins to Main Street contains **5+ café options, 8+ sit-down restaurants, 5+ bars/taprooms, 2 breweries, and 1 distillery** within 0.5 miles. For a suburb of 52,000, this is notable density. The question is whether it constitutes a "scene" — a place where creative and professional energy concentrates and generates spontaneous connection.

**The honest answer: it's getting there but isn't there yet.** For seed-stage conversations, angel meetings, and regular co-founder dinners, downtown Bothell works well. Krō Bär plus Amaro

Bistro is a credible one-two punch. For Series A+ VC dinners with out-of-town investors who expect to be impressed, you'll drive to Kirkland (Café Juanita, \$200+ prix-fixe, James Beard-level) or Woodinville wine country (The Herbfarm, destination tasting rooms). The **1,300+ new downtown residents** delivered since 2014, the UW Bothell student body, and the McMenamins hotel guests create a baseline of foot traffic that supports the existing venues — but the scene doesn't yet generate the critical mass of spontaneous encounters that defines a true networking hub.

### The 3 anchor venues defining social gravity

**McMenamins Anderson School** is the physical and cultural anchor — everyone in Bothell knows it, and its five-acre campus functions as the neighborhood's living room. **Krō Bär** is the aspirational anchor — its 500-spirit collection ([Seattlecocktailweek](#)) and World Class-ranked bartender signal that downtown Bothell's sophistication has crossed a threshold that matters. **Beardslee Public House** is the community anchor — John Howie's brewery-restaurant ([Bothellkenmorechamber](#)) near UW Bothell where locals bring visitors and families celebrate milestones.

### Gaps worth noting

The corridor lacks a **high-end steakhouse** (nearest: John Howie Steak, Bellevue, 20-min drive), a **rooftop bar**, **waterfront dining** (nearest: Kirkland waterfront, 15-min drive), **upscale sushi**, a **dedicated wine bar** (though Krō Bär's list is substantial and Woodinville is 10 minutes away), and reliable **late-night energy** — most venues close by 10 PM weeknights, 11 PM on weekends. There is no dedicated **co-working café** built for remote workers. The ethnic-restaurant depth (Indian, Brazilian, Korean) is strong within the broader Bothell area but mostly requires driving to the Bothell-Everett Highway corridor.

### Competitive comparison

**Vs. Kirkland waterfront (15-min drive south):** Kirkland wins on waterfront views, fine-dining ceiling (Café Juanita is James Beard-level), restaurant density, and overall polish. Bothell wins on authenticity, price-to-quality ratio, indie character, and the McMenamins campus as a unique social asset. **Use case split:** Kirkland for impressing; Bothell for living.

**Vs. Redmond Town Center (20-min drive east):** Redmond offers more retail integration and Microsoft proximity. Bothell has more independent, chef-driven restaurants, more walkable character, and Seattle Met recognition. Bothell's food scene is objectively more interesting.

**Vs. Canyon Park (3 mi north):** Mostly chains — Outback, Bonefish Grill, Ivar's. Strip-mall character. Categorically different from downtown Bothell's independent-led corridor.

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## SECTION 3 — BUSINESS ENVIRONMENT & FOOT TRAFFIC ASSESSMENT

### Commercial corridor character

Downtown Bothell's commercial corridor runs along **Main Street** (partially pedestrianized) and **Bothell Way NE**, anchored by McMenamins at the north and Park at Bothell Landing at the south. The tenant mix is **approximately 80–85% independent businesses** — a ratio that signals authentic commercial culture rather than formula retail. The City of Bothell has actively cultivated this through its **Pop Shops incubator program** (launched March 2021): four pre-fabricated retail buildings at Main Street and Bothell Way housing women-owned and minority-owned micro-businesses ([Bothell WA](#)) selling produce, jewelry, ceramics, and body care products, open Thursday–Sunday.

The dominant category is **food and beverage**, followed by specialty retail and personal services. Ground-floor retail includes Wanderlust Book Lounge (indie bookstore, 6-min walk), Zulu's Board Game Café, ([Begin at Bothell](#)) CoCapsules ([Begin at Bothell](#)) (fashion), First and Main Design Market ([Begin at Bothell](#)) (furniture), Willard Art and Frame, ([Begin at Bothell](#)) Se-lyn Boutique (crystals/jewelry), and Seattle Electric Bike. The Junction, a 6-story mixed-use building adjacent to McMenamins, contains **130 apartments, 10,000 SF of retail, and 30,000 SF of Class A office** ([Mspgroupllc](#)) (occupied by The Everett Clinic). The city's comprehensive plan notes that restaurant demand roughly equals supply (pull factor ~1.0), while **several retail categories show leakage** ([Bothell WA](#)) — meaning residents drive elsewhere for those purchases. This leakage represents a quantifiable market opportunity for the right entrant.

### Foot traffic patterns

**Weekday daytime:** Moderate. Driven by UW Bothell/Cascadia students and staff (~7,000+ combined), McMenamins hotel guests, City Hall employees, The Everett Clinic patients, and local residents. Caffè Ladro and QFC generate steady morning traffic on Bothell Way.

**Weekday evening:** Building. The 1,300+ new apartment residents created since 2014 ([HeraldNet.com](#)) (plus 369 Alexan Bothell units delivered in 2024) are generating a growing dinner-hour customer base. McMenamins' evening venues (The Shed, Nui Nui) and Main Street restaurants (Amaro, Krō Bär, The Bine) draw the evening crowd. Energy tapers after 9–10 PM.

**Weekend:** Strongest period. Burke-Gilman/Sammamish River Trail cyclists and walkers generate significant daytime foot traffic. McMenamins pool, theater, and brewery draw families and couples. Main Street dining and retail peak on Saturday afternoons. Pop Shops are open Thursday–Sunday. ([Begin at Bothell](#))

**Summer peak:** Highest foot traffic of the year. Summer Nights in Bothell (weekly Friday concerts, 300–600 attendees), amphitheater events at Bothell Landing, kayak/SUP traffic on the Sammamish River, and peak trail usage create consistent weekend crowds.

## Key traffic generators driving this block

**McMenamins Anderson School** is the single largest commercial draw — a 72-room hotel ([The Herald](#)) ([Wikipedia](#)) with ([Visit Seattle](#)) 7 F&B venues, a pool, a cinema, and event spaces ([mcmenamins](#)) hosting 2–3 events per week generating 50–600 attendees each. **UW Bothell** (record **6,361 enrollment**, 94% commuters) ([University of Washington B...](#)) drives significant weekday traffic into the adjacent corridor. **The Burke-Gilman/Sammamish River Trail** (30-mile continuous paved trail) ([King County](#)) routes cyclists and runners directly through downtown Bothell. **Pop Keeney Stadium** (adjacent to McMenamins) draws thousands for high school football, soccer, and special events. **Park at Bothell Landing's** amphitheater (600 capacity) hosts summer concert series, holiday events, and community gatherings.

## Tech ecosystem within 5 miles

The density of tech and biotech employment near this address is a structural commercial advantage often underestimated by outsiders.

**Canyon Park corridor (3–4 miles north):** Over **10,000 employees** across a concentrated cluster. ([Bothell WA](#)) **AGC Biologics** (global CDMO headquarters, biologics/mRNA/cell therapy manufacturing). ([Agcbio](#)) **IonQ** (opened February 2024, 105,000 SF quantum computing manufacturing facility — first in the U.S. ([IonQ](#)) — with plans to invest **\$1 billion over 10 years** in the Pacific Northwest). ([HeraldNet.com](#)) **Panasonic Avionics** ([Homes.com](#)) (in-flight entertainment, serves 300+ airlines globally). ([Wikipedia](#)) ([Dun & Bradstreet](#)) **Pfizer/former Seagen** campus (~1,500 Seattle-area employees following \$43B acquisition). ([Connect CRE](#)) **Philips Healthcare, Lockheed Martin**, ([Homes.com](#)) **Silicon Mechanics**. ([Bothell Blog](#)) Bothell hosts Washington's **Biomedical Innovation Partnership Zone** with 60+ life science companies. ([Bothell WA](#))

**UW Bothell (0.8 mi):** AACSB-accredited business school ([University of Washington B...](#)) ([University of Washington B...](#)) with entrepreneurship concentration, CS and STEM programs, makerspace, connection to UW CoMotion incubator (300+ companies spun out, \$9.9B+ raised). ([University of Washington](#)) **Center for Biotech Innovation and Training** with \$750K federal funding ([GeekWire](#)) connecting to 60+ local biotech employers.

**Co-working options:** Regus Canyon Park West (\$129/month hot desk, \$465/month private office). ([CoworkingCafe](#)) Premier Workspaces (19125 North Creek Pkwy). Treefort (community-focused, highly rated). ([Yelp](#)) LiquidSpace on-demand offices.

## Commercial real estate signals

**Lease rates:** Average commercial rent across Bothell is **\$23.73/SF** ([CommercialCafe](#)). ([CommercialCafe](#)) Retail space averages **~\$36/SF** ([LoopNet](#)), predominantly NNN. This is roughly **40–50% below** comparable Bellevue retail and 25–30% below Kirkland — a meaningful cost advantage for an independent operator or startup.



**Inventory:** 98–99 commercial listings for lease across Bothell totaling ~897,000 SF. (PropertyShark) Office dominates (55% of available space), retail represents 25%. (CommercialSearch) Most retail spaces are **1,000–2,500 SF** (18 listings in this range). North Creek neighborhood holds the highest concentration of listings; Canyon Park leads in retail. (CommercialCafe)

**Development pipeline:** The Alexan Bothell (369 units, Trammell Crow Residential) delivered (Grahambuilds) in 2024. Avalon Bothell Commons (800 units, AvalonBay) is in development. (Multi-Housing News) **Over 1,000 new housing units are in pre-application** as of 2025, with a 45% increase in units-per-project driven by 2024 zoning reforms. (The Urbanist) The city has approved an affordable housing project on Lot P South (~200 units). (Bothell WA) UW Bothell is planning 658 additional student housing beds. This pipeline signals sustained developer confidence in the market.

**Vacancy:** No published downtown-specific vacancy rate exists, but active development, the Pop Shops incubator filling vacant lots with micro-retail, and the Main Street Enhancement Project (\$4.7M TIB grant for streetscape improvements) suggest limited core-corridor vacancies. The broader Puget Sound suburban office market has elevated vacancy (~19.7% nationally as of early 2025), and Bothell's office market is likely softer than its retail/restaurant market.

### Event economy

McMenamins hosts **2–3 events per week** year-round (concerts, History Pub lectures, comedy, drag brunch, brewfests) with Haynes' Hall accommodating up to 600 guests. Park at Bothell Landing's amphitheater hosts Summer Nights in Bothell (weekly Friday concerts, July–August, 300–600 attendees), Music in the Park series, Movies in the Park, and the Holiday Light Display. Northshore Performing Arts Center (600-seat theater, 0.5 mi) hosts concerts and theater productions. (Begin at Bothell) The **Bothell Holiday Market** (December, Festival Street) (Seattle's Child) and Making Local Markets (recurring artisan markets) supplement the recurring calendar. Collectively, this event infrastructure generates **meaningful but seasonal** foot traffic peaks, with summer representing the commercial high-water mark.

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## SECTION 4 — EDUCATIONAL REALITY

**Low priority for this persona, noted briefly.** Northshore School District ranks **12th of 247 districts** in Washington (SchoolDigger, 5/5 stars), (SchoolDigger) with 63% math and 75% reading proficiency (Niche) — well above state averages of 41% and 53%. Bothell High School carries a **9/10 GreatSchools rating**, a 97% graduation rate (Homes.com) (vs. 84% statewide), and average SAT scores of 1300. These metrics are relevant primarily as **property value drivers** supporting real estate investment.

**Far more relevant for this persona:** UW Bothell and Cascadia College share a (Begin at Bothell) 128-acre campus (U.S. News & World Report) **15 minutes on foot** from McMenamins. UW Bothell hit record

enrollment of **6,361 students** in autumn 2025 (up 4.7% YoY), (King 5) with an enrollment cap agreement with the city at 10,000 FTE. (Wikipedia) The campus generates a **\$394 million annual economic impact** (University of Washington B...) and produces graduates in Computer Science, Engineering, Business (with entrepreneurship concentration), and Biotech. Two-thirds of its **34,000+ alumni** remain within 25 miles. (University of Washington B...) Cascadia's BS in Computer Science and technical certificates feed directly into the local tech workforce. This is a **walkable, growing talent pipeline** — the single most actionable educational asset at this address for a tech entrepreneur.

## SECTION 5 — COMMUTE TRUTH

### Drive times from McMenamins Anderson School

| Destination                                  | Off-Peak  | Peak Hour | Primary Route                       |
|----------------------------------------------|-----------|-----------|-------------------------------------|
| Bellevue tech corridor (T-Mobile HQ, Amazon) | 15-20 min | 30-50 min | I-405 S                             |
| Kirkland (Google, Tableau/Salesforce)        | 12-18 min | 25-40 min | I-405 S or surface via 124th Ave NE |
| Redmond (Microsoft HQ, Nintendo)             | 20-25 min | 35-55 min | I-405 S → SR-520 E                  |
| South Lake Union, Seattle (Amazon, Meta)     | 25 min    | 40-60 min | SR-522 W → I-5 S                    |
| Everett (Boeing)                             | 18-25 min | 30-45 min | I-405 N / I-5 N                     |
| SEA-TAC Airport                              | 33-40 min | 60-90 min | I-405 S → I-5 S or SR-167           |

### The I-405 / SR-522 congestion reality

The morning southbound commute on I-405 toward Bellevue is **the region's most congested corridor**. A single express toll lane between SR-522 and Lynnwood creates a bottleneck that can double travel times. (WSDOT) Express toll lane prices regularly exceed **\$10+ during peak congestion**. WSDOT's I-405/Brickyard to SR-527 project is expanding to dual express toll lanes through Bothell, (WSDOT) but construction is active through 2027+ — meaning **frequent**

**weekend closures of I-405 and SR-522** [\(Washington State Departm...\)](#) in 2026, with speed limits reduced to 35 MPH on portions of SR-522. [\(Blogger\)](#) Two new signalized intersections on SR-522 at the I-405 interchange [\(Washington State Departm...\)](#) (installed November 2025) add approximately 1 minute to peak-hour travel times. [\(Washington State Departm...\)](#) The honest assessment: the commute is workable for a tech entrepreneur with schedule flexibility who avoids the 7–9 AM and 4–7 PM peaks. It is genuinely painful for anyone locked into a fixed rush-hour commute.

## **Stride S3 BRT: the game-changer arriving Q2 2028**

**Groundbreaking:** February/March 2026 (ceremony held in Kenmore). **Opening:** Q2 2028.

**Budget:** \$581.5 million. [\(Sound Transit\)](#) **Fleet:** 15 sixty-foot battery-electric buses running every **10–15 minutes**, 17+ hours per day, 7 days per week. [\(Sound Transit\)](#) The S3 line runs 14 stations from Shoreline South/148th (connecting directly to Link Light Rail) through Lake Forest Park and Kenmore to Bothell. [\(Sound Transit\)](#) [\(Seattle Transit Blog\)](#) The **104th Ave NE station** will sit approximately **0.3 miles from McMenamins** — essentially the "Anderson School stop." Bothell-to-Shoreline travel time drops from up to 59 minutes today to **~22–35 minutes**, [\(Sound Transit\)](#) with a direct transfer to Link Light Rail for one-seat access to UW Seattle, Capitol Hill, downtown Seattle, and eventually SEA-TAC. When the Stride S2 line opens in 2029 (I-405, Lynnwood to Bellevue), [\(Sound Transit\)](#) Bothell becomes the **convergence point of two BRT lines** [\(KenmoreCommunityClub\)](#) — a rare transit advantage for a suburban location.

## **SEA-TAC verdict**

**28 miles away, and it shows.** Off-peak: 33–40 minutes, manageable. [\(Rome2Rio\)](#) Peak hour: 60–90 minutes, requiring departure planning. No direct transit option until S3 + Link connection in 2028, and even then the total transit time will be approximately 90–100 minutes. Rideshare estimates ~\$90. [\(Uber\)](#) For a tech entrepreneur who flies 2–4 times per month, this is a friction point — not a dealbreaker, but a real scheduling constraint. **The optimal strategy:** Use the express toll lanes (\$10–15 premium), travel off-peak when possible, and consider airport hotels for early-morning departures.

## **Overall commute verdict**

Bothell works well for an entrepreneur whose primary orbit is the **Eastside** (Bellevue, Kirkland, Redmond) — all reachable in 12–25 minutes off-peak. It works adequately for Seattle access with schedule flexibility. It works poorly for a fixed rush-hour commute to South Lake Union. It works inconveniently for frequent flying. **The trajectory is strongly positive:** by 2029, dual express toll lanes, Stride S3, Stride S2, and Swift Green Line extension will collectively transform Bothell from car-dependent to genuinely multi-modal. An entrepreneur who establishes a base here in 2026 will experience the worst of the commute disruption now and the best of the infrastructure payoff within 3 years.

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## SECTION 6 — NEIGHBORHOOD TRAJECTORY

### The revitalization arc: 2006 to present

Downtown Bothell's transformation began with the **2006 Downtown Subarea Plan** and a five-year visioning process that led to the city acting as master developer — purchasing approximately **26 acres** of land to replace strip malls and auto-oriented businesses with a walkable urban center. The **\$150 million downtown redevelopment program** broke ground in 2010. The pivotal infrastructure move was the **SR-522 realignment** (2010–2014), which moved the state highway one block south, removed **44,000+ daily vehicles** from historic Main Street, and created the physical preconditions for a pedestrian-oriented downtown. McMenamins Anderson School opened in **October 2015**, establishing the commercial anchor. A new **\$47 million City Hall** opened the same year. MainStreet Property Group then delivered over **650 apartments and 55,000+ SF of retail** across four projects (Six Oaks, The Junction, The POP, The Landing) between 2015 and 2019. In June 2020, one block of Main Street was pedestrianized — initially a COVID response, now permanent. Trammell Crow Residential's **Alexan Bothell** (369 units) delivered in 2024. AvalonBay's **Avalon Bothell Commons** (800 units on 23 acres) is in development.

### The policy signals that matter most

The City of Bothell's **2024–2025 zoning reforms** are among the most aggressive pro-growth moves by any Eastside city. The **Imagine Bothell Comprehensive Plan** (approved December 2024) establishes a 20-year growth framework designating downtown as a **255-acre Community Activity Center** with minimum density requirements. In 2025, the city **eliminated all off-street parking requirements** citywide and legalized commercial storefronts in all residential zones. Pre-applications for new housing surged past **1,000 units** for the first time, with a 45% increase in units per project (one townhome project jumped from 18 to 79 units under the new code). The city's **2025 median family income** hit **\$157,100** — reflecting the high-earning tech and biotech workforce. The housing target through 2044 is **12,782 new units**, effectively doubling the city's housing stock.

### Where Bothell sits on the maturity curve

Bothell is in **mid-transformation** — past the speculative phase but with significant room to mature. The infrastructure backbone is complete (highway relocation, multiway boulevard, pedestrianized Main Street, new City Hall, BRT under construction). The first development wave is delivered and occupied. A second wave, enabled by zoning reform, is building. Kirkland's downtown waterfront is **5–8 years ahead** on the maturity curve — with an established fine-dining scene, Google's campus, and high property values. Bellevue's Bel-Red corridor represents a much larger-scale corporate transformation. Redmond's Old Town is on a similar trajectory to Bothell but benefits from Link Light Rail arrival. **Bothell's differentiators:** one of the few Eastside suburbs with a genuine pre-war historic downtown (incorporated 1909); a lower cost

basis (townhomes from high \$700Ks vs. Kirkland/Bellevue premiums); a unique entertainment anchor in McMenamins; and an organic, independent-led commercial character that corporate-driven corridors struggle to replicate.

## The Seattle Met signal

Seattle Met's December 2025 designation of Bothell as **Culinary Suburb of the Year** is third-party validation from the region's premier lifestyle publication. Food writer Allecia Vermillion specifically cited ILMU's tasting menu ("the best meal I ate last year"), T55 Pâtisserie's pain au chocolat, Tá Jóia's Brazilian-Korean fusion, De La Soil's farm-to-table sourcing, and **at least three top-tier Indian restaurants** in Bothell. The article credits **Seattle's high commercial rents** as pushing serious chefs to Bothell — a structural migration pattern that will likely accelerate given the city's 2025 zoning reforms legalizing neighborhood cafés and corner stores everywhere. The pedestrianized downtown and Burke-Gilman Trail were called out as making the dining experience pleasant and walkable. This recognition signals that the food scene's improvement is not random but reflects economic forces (rent arbitrage, chef migration) that will continue.

## Risk factors to track

**Congestion:** SR-522 carries 96,000 vehicles daily at the I-405 interchange. The Stride BRT timeline has already slipped from 2024 to 2028; further delays are possible. The I-405 interchange reconstruction creates real 2026–2027 disruption. **Housing affordability:** Median home price has reached approximately **\$945K** (Redfin, February 2026); average apartment rent is **\$2,007–\$2,284/month**. New construction median sale price is \$1.44M. Rents have softened 1.3–2.4% YoY, suggesting new supply is being absorbed but the market is price-sensitive. **Potential oversupply:** 1,000+ units in pre-application create a concentration risk in the \$2,000–\$2,500/month rental band (currently 47% of market). **Community tension:** Some residents have expressed concerns about concentrated downtown change, parking loss, and growth pace. The city's response has been to "spread growth more evenly across Bothell."

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## SECTION 7 — HIDDEN ASSET & HIDDEN RISK

### Hidden asset: The two-line BRT convergence node

Most market analysis of Bothell focuses on the Stride S3 line (Shoreline to Bothell, opening Q2 2028). What's less widely understood is that **Bothell will become the convergence point of two Stride BRT lines** when S2 (I-405, Lynnwood to Bellevue) opens in 2029. The S3 terminus at the Bothell/Woodinville Transit Center will directly connect to S2, creating a multi-directional transit hub. Combined with the Swift Green Line extension to UW Bothell (planned 2028–2031 by Community Transit), downtown Bothell will have **three BRT lines converging within a mile** — a density of rapid transit service that no other Eastside suburb outside Bellevue will match. Transit hubs historically generate commercial density, property value appreciation, and foot

traffic growth that compounds over time. This structural advantage is funded, under construction, and arriving within 3 years — yet it is almost entirely absent from current commercial real estate marketing for the area.

### **Hidden risk: The thin commercial corridor's fragility**

Downtown Bothell's walkable commercial core is **genuinely narrow** — essentially two blocks of Main Street and a half-mile stretch of Bothell Way NE. The entire dining/retail identity rests on roughly **20–25 independent operators**. A single major vacancy (imagine Amaro Bistro or Krō Bär closing), a sustained McMenamins operational shift, or a prolonged construction disruption from the Main Street Enhancement Project could visibly diminish the corridor's vitality in a way that would be imperceptible on a larger commercial street. The 80–85% independent ratio that gives downtown Bothell its character is also a vulnerability: independents are more capital-constrained and more sensitive to foot traffic dips than national chains. The corridor needs to continue adding operators — not just housing units — to build the redundancy that makes a commercial district resilient. The 2025 zoning reform legalizing neighborhood commercial is a step in the right direction, but the current equilibrium is fragile.

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## **SECTION 8 — DAY IN THE LIFE**

The morning starts at Caffè Ladro, directly across Bothell Way — close enough that the walk takes less time than the espresso. He takes a window seat with his laptop, connects to WiFi, and works through his inbox and Slack channels while the barista pulls a double-shot flat white. Ladro is good — not an artisanal temple, but a serious Seattle roaster with the right energy. By 8:30 AM, the UW Bothell crowd starts trickling past on foot, heading east along Beardslee Boulevard. He watches them and thinks about the CS intern he's planning to recruit from the School of Business. The campus is a 15-minute walk; he'll go for a coffee meeting there next week with the entrepreneurship program director.

By mid-morning, he's back at his apartment — or, if the weather's good, he's taken his laptop to The Shed at McMenamins, where the outdoor fireplace is already lit and the courtyard is quiet enough to take a Zoom call. McMenamins functions as his unofficial office campus — free WiFi, multiple bars that serve as different "rooms" depending on the mood, and a 35-seat community room (Thorndike Room) that he can reserve for free when he needs a proper meeting space. He's got a 10 AM call with a co-founder candidate in Bellevue; they'll meet for lunch tomorrow at Beardslee Public House, which is casual enough to feel like a real conversation and serious enough that the craft beer list and in-house distillery show he lives somewhere with taste. If the meeting goes well, he'll bring them back to Krō Bär on Friday evening — the 500-spirit collection and the 16-foot tin ceilings make an impression, and the fact that the owner is a fellow tech founder gives the place a credibility that money can't buy.

Afternoon, he drives to a client meeting in Kirkland — 14 minutes on I-405 at 2 PM, before the evening bottleneck sets in. He's learned to schedule all his southbound drives between 10 AM and 3 PM or after 7 PM; the I-405 express toll lane is his insurance policy when timing slips. He's back by 4:30 and heads to Park at Bothell Landing for a 30-minute run on the Sammamish River Trail — flat, paved, lined with cottonwoods, and blissfully empty on a Tuesday afternoon. The trail goes all the way to Marymoor Park in Redmond or west to Seattle via the Burke-Gilman; on weekends, he bikes to Woodinville wine country in 15 minutes.

Dinner is at Amaro Bistro — three minutes on foot, no reservation needed on a Tuesday, handmade pappardelle and a glass of Barolo at the bar. The host knows his name by now. If he's feeling social, he walks to Main Street afterward: Krō Bär if he wants cocktails and conversation, The Bine if he wants a burger and a beer and a game on the TV, or McMenamins' movie theater if he just wants to sit in a rocker seat with a craft ale and watch something on the big screen. The evening is quiet by 10 PM — this is not Capitol Hill, and the late-night energy he sometimes misses is the one thing the corridor doesn't yet deliver. But the morning comes early, and the espresso at Ladro will be waiting.

On the weekend, he checks the McMenamins event calendar: a live music show in Haynes' Hall on Saturday, a History Pub lecture on Thursday. He's hosting a small team off-site in the Thorndike Room on Monday. When his investor flies in from San Francisco, he books a room at Anderson School itself — the investor walks the campus, swims in the saltwater pool, and tells him over dinner at Amaro that the vibe reminds him of a Portland district that's about to tip. He knows. That's why he's here.

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## **SECTION 9 — THE LOCUS VERDICT**

### **CONDITIONAL FIT — for a middle-aged single male tech entrepreneur conducting market analysis**

This is a strong and improving location with genuine commercial upside, but it has not yet crossed the density and scene threshold that would make it an unconditional recommendation for this persona. The structural catalysts are funded and arriving (BRT, zoning reform, institutional capital), the cost basis is favorable relative to Kirkland and Bellevue, and the McMenamins campus is a unique anchor that no competing corridor can replicate. But the social scene is still thin after 10 PM, the commute to Seattle and SEA-TAC requires active schedule management, and the commercial corridor is narrow enough that its vitality depends on a small number of independent operators.

#### **Three conditions that would change the verdict to Strong Fit:**

- **Stride S3 opens on schedule (Q2 2028) and drives measurable foot traffic to downtown Bothell.** The 104th Ave NE station 0.3 miles from McMenamins will be the litmus test — if

it generates consistent new pedestrian traffic into the dining corridor, the commercial calculus shifts materially.

- **Two or more chef-driven restaurant openings land in downtown Bothell within the next 18 months.** The Seattle Met recognition and rent-arbitrage dynamics make this plausible. ILMU's transition from pop-up to permanent, or a comparable arrival, would signal the food scene has reached escape velocity.
- **A dedicated co-working space or tech-community hub opens within walking distance of McMenamins.** The Thorndike Room is a workaround; a purpose-built space with programming would convert this from a residential neighborhood with commercial amenities into a genuine work-live corridor.

**One non-negotiable that should drive the final decision:**

**Spend a full working week operating from this address before committing capital.** Book a room at McMenamins for five weekday nights. Work from Caffè Ladro, The Shed, and the Thorndike Room. Drive to Bellevue, Kirkland, and Seattle at peak hours. Eat dinner at Amaro, Krō Bär, and Beardslee. Run the Sammamish River Trail. Feel the energy — or its absence — after 9 PM on a Wednesday. The data in this dossier supports a positive thesis, but the critical variable for this persona is whether the current social density generates enough spontaneous connection and creative energy to sustain a productive, connected life. That is a felt experience, not a spreadsheet metric.

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## **SECTION 10 — 30-DAY DECISION CHECKLIST**

**1. Conduct the five-night immersion test.** Book McMenamins Anderson School for a full Monday-through-Friday stay. Work from three different locations (Caffè Ladro, McMenamins campus, Beardslee Blvd corridor). Take all peak-hour drives. Eat at five different restaurants. Quantify how many spontaneous professional-quality interactions you have versus how many you had to manufacture.

**2. Meet with UW Bothell's entrepreneurship program.** Contact the School of Business (Beardslee Building, 18807 Beardslee Blvd) and request a meeting with the director of the entrepreneurship concentration. Ask about internship pipelines, startup mentorship programs, and the density of student founders. Evaluate whether this is a real talent source or a brochure talking point.

**3. Tour 2-3 commercial spaces and get current lease comparables.** Walk into Premier Workspaces (19125 North Creek Pkwy) and Regus Canyon Park West (22722 29th Dr SE). Pull LoopNet listings for downtown Bothell retail under 2,500 SF. Get actual NNN quotes and tenant



improvement allowances. Compare to equivalent space in Kirkland and Bellevue to validate the cost advantage in real dollars.

**4. Attend a McMenamins event and a Main Street evening.** Go to a live music show in Haynes' Hall on a Saturday and a Thursday evening on Main Street. Count the number of people between 7-10 PM. Note the demographic mix. Determine whether this foot traffic is growing or static by talking to two or three business owners on Main Street — ask them directly how 2025 compared to 2024.

**5. Review the City of Bothell development pipeline map.** Request the current project list from the Economic Development Coordinator (Ashis Joshi, City of Bothell, 18415 101st Ave NE). Ask specifically about commercial development pre-applications within 0.5 miles of McMenamins, the Main Street Enhancement Project timeline, and any tenants signed for ground-floor retail in upcoming residential projects. Cross-reference with the Imagine Bothell Comprehensive Plan (approved December 2024) to understand where density is being directed over the next 5-10 years.